

SAS-002 | Student Aid Bursary Program Policy

PURPOSE & SCOPE

1. The overarching goal of the Student Aid Bursary Program (SABP) is to provide a direct, equitable, and transparent financial supplement to undergraduate students at the University of Toronto St. George campus who face financial hardship. This policy defines a bursary program rooted in the principles of anti-oppression, objective financial need, and reproducible governance of student funds.
2. This policy applies to all members of the UTSU seeking bursaries, professional faculty grants, or emergency financial assistance under this program, as well as the staff and committee members charged with evaluating applications and disbursing aid.

POLICY

1. Dignity and Data Governance

- This program shall strictly adhere to data minimization principles to uphold applicants' dignity, privacy, and respect.
- The collection, processing, and use of information shall be limited to information necessary to assess financial need, generate internal program reports, produce public figures, and create anonymized aggregate analytics.
- The program may also utilize or publish fully anonymized data (e.g., individual questionnaire responses) for research purposes. However, explicit consent must be obtained from the applicant before using or publishing any research involving identifiable information, including general statements.
- The practicalities of running this program shall require applications to be submitted via an online form, such as Google Forms, and processed using a high-level programming language such as Python.
- Explicit requests for data destruction shall be honoured.

2. Principles and Method of Determining Financial Need

- Financial need shall be evaluated using a holistic, mixed-methods approach that combines qualitative and quantitative measures. The following prompts shall be used:
 - A requested amount shall be requested to evaluate one's specific need.
 - A general statement describing the impact of such amount on one's well-being.
 - A standard questionnaire shall be administered to compute a *Weighted Financial Need Index (WFNI)* to support the prioritization and eligibility of certain applications.

- The *Weighted Financial Need Index* shall consider the following factors:
 - **Disability & Accessibility Status:** Accounting for out-of-pocket medical, caregiving, or adaptive technology expenses.
 - **Dependents & Remittance Obligations:** Weighting for applicants supporting family members or sending financial care abroad.
 - **Housing & Living Wage Ratio:** Adjusting for local housing costs relative to the current living wage in Toronto.
 - **Disposable Income & Contribution Thresholds:** Factoring in personal earnings, familial income, and expected parental/spousal contributions.
 - **Tuition Fee Status:** Distinguishing between domestic and international tuition and program structures to ensure fair assessments.
- Every applicant shall be treated on a trust-but-verify basis, with an emphasis on internal application consistency rather than the authoritative certification of need. Should the committee identify any inconsistencies or require further documentation in support of an application, the VPFO is responsible for ensuring the applicant clarifies and resolves the matter.

3. **Emergency Bursary Provision**

A minimum of 5% of the yearly program budget shall be earmarked to assist students experiencing sudden, unforeseen financial crises throughout the academic year (e.g., immediate risk of eviction, acute food insecurity, unmanageable emergency medical expenses, or sudden safety disruptions).

4. **Equity & Anti-Oppression Alignment**

The framework and its execution shall prohibit discrimination on the basis of protected grounds. Program parameters prioritize removing barriers for historically marginalized and underrepresented student populations.

5. **Fiduciary Responsibilities & Confidentiality**

In accordance with fiduciary obligations:

- The VPFO and their delegates shall be tasked with administering the program, including data protection, application processing, and general operations.
 - The VPFO is empowered to delegate certain administrative tasks, yet is responsible for overseeing decisions made in its administration and implementation.
- The VPFO shall ask the members of the Student Aid & Scholarships Committee to review a subset of pre-processed, anonymized applications that contain the previously defined prompts to decide.
- All personal, financial, and supporting documentation submitted by applicants shall remain strictly confidential, unless specified elsewhere in this document.
 - At the request of the Committee, an application shall be unblinded after a two-thirds vote, with the concern documented in committee minutes.
- Aggregate reports shall be presented to the Board of Directors by the VPFO periodically.

Program Structure, Determinations and Application Maximums

The program shall be structured as a year-round program, with applications considered on an ongoing basis according to the following rules:

- Each applicant shall be a UTSU member, as defined by their membership dues status, during the term in which they apply.
- Each applicant shall be eligible to receive up to a **yearly maximum of \$3,500**.
- Each applicant shall identify the funding stream for which they wish to be considered. Consideration under each stream shall aim to maximize the applicant's requested amount. Applicants shall only be considered for one funding stream per term; the order of preference shall be as follows.
 1. **Living-costs Assistance Bursary Stream (LABs):** Up to \$1,500 max. per term.
 - a. **Transit Mobility Subsidy (TMS):** Up to \$500 per term
 - i. Determination is made on a distance-based calculation (i.e. nearest GO Station to Union).
 - b. **Healthy Living Subsidy (HLS):** Up to \$300 per term
 - i. Determination is based on their description of what they wish to purchase that would meaningfully improve their quality of life in their general statement.
 - c. **Emergency Bursary (EB):** Prioritized review process providing up to an additional \$1,000 in funding
 2. **Academic Pursuit Reimbursement Stream (APRs):** Up to \$1500 max. per term.
 - a. Exam Deferral Reimbursement: Approximately \$150 per term
 - i. Determination is based on the course names provided in their general statement and an optional supplementary image of their ACORN Academic History showing an IPR or an SDF.
 - b. Conference Reimbursement: Approximately \$350 per term
 - i. Determination is made based on the quality of their general statement and an itemized list of expenses they wish to claim.
 - c. Mandatory Placement Stipend: Approximately \$500 per term.
 - i. Determination is made based on verification of their year of study, status as a healthcare-aligned professional faculty member, and attestation of need in their general statement.
 3. **Professional Faculty Summer Gym Access Reimbursement (PFS-GABs):**
 - a. Determination is made via verification of Professional Faculty Status and an attestation that they will use this bursary towards Gym access.
- For applications requesting under \$150, instant approval may be granted at the discretion of the VPFO, PROVIDED that the total amounts for instant approval are less than \$5,000 per term and that the General Manager signs off on the request. Notice of instant approvals must be provided at the next committee meeting.

Program Funds Allocation and Timelines

The allocation of program funds shall adhere to the schedule set out in the table below. The Vice-President Finance & Operations (VPFO) and the Financial Controller are charged with monitoring compliance and flagging any discrepancies. However, the Student Aid Committee retains the authority to override these allocations by decision at any meeting.

Term	Yearly Allocation	Tolerance	Term End/Dates
Fall	35%	± 5–10%	September 1st - December 31st
Winter	35%	± 5–10%	January 1st - April 30th
Summer (+ PF Gym)	17.5%	± 5–10%	May 1st - August 31st
Emergencies	12.5% (up to a maximum of \$20,000, CPI.s.2026)	± 5%	

The VPFO shall ensure that the application is ready to go live at least a week before each term-end.

Compliance Requirements

- Record Keeping:** The Student Aid Committee shall maintain a continuous record of annual disbursements and individual disbursement decisions.
 - Applicants shall be identified solely by their University of Toronto student number. Each entry must log both the requested amount and the actual disbursement, rounded to two significant figures.
 - Upon completion of application processing and successful direct deposit of funds, the UTSU shall securely destroy any applicant's personal information that cannot be retained under the Dignity and Data Governance clause.
- Application Censoring:** When preparing files for committee review, the Vice-President, Operations, must redact all personally identifiable information to prevent bias during adjudication.
- Closed Sessions:** The Student Aid Committee shall conduct its meeting proceedings in closed session.
- Reporting and Board Minutes:** In alignment with good governance standards and relevant board policies, minutes submitted to the Board of Directors for approval shall contain only high-level summaries:

- a. **Discussion Summaries:** Discussion summaries must omit any personal details or specific descriptions of applicants or individual applications. Permissible topics are limited to:
 - i. Procedural matters;
 - ii. Review of committee-related governing documents;
 - iii. Deliberations and voting records on formal motions; and
 - iv. Formal approval of final disbursement totals.
- b. **Decision Summaries:** A summary of actions taken during the meeting, comprising:
 - i. Total funds authorized per individual bursary category;
 - ii. Combined total funds authorized across all bursaries;
 - iii. Cumulative program budget expenditure to date, expressed as both a numerical sum and a percentage;
 - iv. Aggregate counts of approved and rejected applications; and
 - v. The number of approved exceptions where funding exceeds standard bursary limits.

Evaluation Framework: General Statement Rubric

Before the committee meeting, each SASC member must review application statements and assign a preliminary score to each candidate. During the meeting, members will deliberate collaboratively to reach a final decision.

Need Level	Recommended Amount (\$ maximums)	Definition
0	\$0	The applicant demonstrates no financial need for bursary assistance (e.g., cases where applications are submitted without sufficient cause).
1	\$125	Minor Expenses: Designed to cover smaller, routine transactions that still strain students financially. Typical coverage includes: minor accessories or electronics (e.g., adapters, computer mice), stationery, notebooks, partial textbook costs, or exam deferral fees.
2	\$300	Moderate Expenses: Targeted toward partially funding major purchases or easing ongoing monthly living costs over a 1–2 month period. Typical coverage includes: partial contributions toward major electronics (laptops, mobile phones, tablets, styluses), 1–2 course textbooks, 1–2 months of TTC transit, or partial assistance with monthly grocery expenses.
3	\$650	Substantial Expenses (Target): Aimed at providing significant financial relief for major costs, or combining Level 2 coverage with support for essential daily necessities (e.g., groceries, personal care items). Typical coverage includes: substantial offsets for major electronics (up to half the cost of a laptop), most or all required textbooks, several months of transit passes, or grocery assistance.
4	\$900	Major Financial Support (Target): Intended for students requiring greater support than Level 3, offering extensive coverage for costly academic and living expenses. Typical coverage includes: full-term transit passes, course textbooks, elevated everyday living support, or over 50% of the cost of mid- to large-scale electronics.

5	\$1500	Emergency & Critical Needs: Designed to address urgent, unanticipated crises (including housing loss, TBC).
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Financial Need Index Weights

Guiding Principles:

- Non-oppressive (assume applicants are truthful and require a low proof threshold)
- Equitable to Underserved Populations
- Data-minimizing

Factor	Assessment Question	Response Options	Point Value	Notes
Disability Status	1. Do you identify as having a disability that impacts your physical mobility?	Yes No	+2 0	* Our recognition of in/visible disabilities shall not rank disabilities, but rather acknowledge the unique costs associated with both.
	2. Do you identify as having an invisible disability that affects your day-to-day functioning?	Yes No	+2 0	
Housing / Living Situation	From the following, in the current or near future, how stable would you consider your current housing situation?	Stably Housed Precariously Housed Imminent risk of losing Housing Emergency sheltered Unsheltered	0 +1 +4 +4 +6	
Access to Disposable Income	Over the past four months, after paying for your basic needs (such as food, housing, and transportation), how much money did your household usually have leftover from its income at the end of each month?	A negative amount (taking on short-term debt to satisfy necessities) Less than \$100 \$100-200 \$200-500 \$500-1000 \$1000+	+5 +4 +3 +2 +0 -3	* Response Options shall be reviewed yearly and adjusted to current economic conditions. *Assumption: having more than \$500 implies a relatively stable financial situation.

Factor	Assessment Question	Response Options	Point Value	Notes
	Info: Household's monthly income minus your monthly essential expenses.			
Liquidity	How much money do you currently have available to you, on-hand and in your bank account, after setting aside any money you need for tuition?	\$0-\$500 \$500-\$1000 \$1000-\$2500 \$2500-\$5000 \$5000-\$7500 \$7500-\$10,000 \$10,000+	+3 +1 +0 -1 -2 -3 -5	*Note: To be equitable to international students, the amount reported shall exclude tuition payments.
Emergent and Extenuating Circumstances	Have you experienced any of the following in the previous four months?	Job Loss / Hour Cutbacks Victim of Interpersonal Violence Took out a loan on credit cards to feed myself Identity Theft Fraud Racism Status issues Recent new disability Recent estrangement	+3 per circumstance, capped at 10. Trust but verify when point totals represent a majority of the point scale.	
Number of Dependents and/or Remittance members	Please identify how many dependents rely on you for their livelihood:	0 1 2 3 4+	0 +1 +2 +3 +4	*Note: should include members who rely on remittances to sustain a positive quality of life.
Access to External Supports	Do you have access to a trusted, accessible and reliable support network? (i.e. someone who would	Yes No	0 +1	

Factor	Assessment Question	Response Options	Point Value	Notes
	house or feed you for one to two nights)			
Structural costs	Please identify which faculty you belong to:			

PROCEDURE (STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE – SOP)

1. SOP Overview & Workflow

The administration of the SABP follows a structured, five-stage cycle designed to guarantee consistency, speed, and privacy.

None

[Stage 1: Intake & Verification] → [Stage 2: Weighted Indexing] → [Stage 3: Anonymized Review] → [Stage 4: Awarding & Decision] → [Stage 5: Disbursement & Audit]

2. Stage 1: Application Intake & Verification

- Application Rounds:** The application shall be open year-round; it shall be digital and universally compliant with the SABP Schema.
- System Maintenance and Code:** A Python package shall be developed, maintained, and governed in accordance with the SABP Schema to facilitate application processing.

3. Stage 2: Automated Member Verification, Indexing & Scoring

- Member Verification:** The intake system shall automatically determine whether the applicant is a valid UTSU member.
- WFNI Multipliers:** Point scoring shall be automated using the weights specified in the SABP policy.

4. Stage 3: Anonymized Adjudication

- Data Anonymization:** Before distribution to the committee, administrative staff redact all personally identifiable information (PII), including legal names, student ID numbers, and contact details.
- Member Evaluation:** Each Student Aid & Scholarships Committee member reviews anonymized applicant profiles against the standardized rubric. They score their general statements according to the rubric.
- Committee Eval:** Committee comes together and then allowed for

Assessment Factor	Weight / Adjustment Indicator	Verification Document Required
Disability Status	Higher weighting for unrecovered medical/care costs	Medical receipt / Accessibility confirmation

Assessment Factor	Weight / Adjustment Indicator	Verification Document Required
Dependents / Remittance	Tiered multiplier based on number of dependents	Tax summary / Remittance receipts
Housing Burden	Ratio of rent to current Toronto living wage	Executed lease / Rent receipts
Fee Category	Normalized domestic vs. international baselines	University fee invoice / SOP proof
Professional / 2nd Entry	Program fee cap adjustment factor	Academic transcript / Fee schedule

4. **Quorum & Delegation:** If the Student Aid & Scholarships Committee fails to achieve a quorum for two (2) consecutive scheduled meetings, the adjudication authority for that cycle is delegated directly to the Management Committee to avoid disbursement delays.

5. Stage 4: Expedited Emergency Protocol

1. **Emergency Intake:** Applications flagged for immediate emergency aid bypass standard review cycles.
2. **Review Window:** Emergency applications must be reviewed by the Chair of the Student Aid Committee and the CAO/General Manager within **forty-eight (48) to seventy-two (72) hours** of receipt.
3. **Emergency Discard Threshold:** Emergency bursaries are capped at \$1,500 per applicant per academic year, unless extended by formal committee approval.

6. Stage 5: Disbursement & Reconciliation

1. **Notification:** Applicants receive written notice of approved funding or detailed feedback on unsuccessful applications via the portal messaging system.
2. **Payment Processing:** Approved awards are submitted to the UTSU Finance Department for Electronic Funds Transfer (EFT) or direct cheque issuance within ten (10) business days of decision.
3. **Audit & Reconciliation:** All disbursements undergo quarterly audit and reconciliation conducted by the Vice-President, Finance & Operations, and the Financial Controller.

7. Allocation of Program Funds

Funding Distribution Table

Semester	Allocation Percentage
Summer	15%
Fall	40%
Winter	40%
Contingency	5%

The Student Aid Committee may award five percent of the total amount of funds allocated for each grant in any semester as a contingency. Any funds not awarded during a semester may be awarded in the following semester.

CITATIONS & APPENDICES

Associated Documents & Governance References

- **UTSU Bylaws:** Bylaw II (Membership).
 - **Terms of Reference:** TOR-009 (Student Aid & Scholarship Committee Terms of Reference).
 - **Board Policy:** P&C Anti-Harassment, Equity, Diversity & Inclusion, and Accessibility Policies.
 - **Template Standards:** Policy & Procedure Manual Standard Format (000-Series).
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Policy Owner: Student Aid & Scholarships Committee

Primary Contact:  Person (VP Finance & Operations)

Approved By: UTSU Board of Directors

Next Review Date:  Date